

Mini Menu Models

Tiny replica dishes on the menu — customers see exactly what they order, then photograph it.

What It Is

Mini Menu Models makes and installs miniature replicas of a restaurant's actual dishes, mounted next to each item on the menu or on a display shelf. Instead of guessing from a name and description, diners see a realistic, shrunk-down version of the food before they order. It removes uncertainty from the buying decision — confident customers order more, leave five-star reviews, and photograph the display, turning the menu itself into shareable content.

How It Makes Money

This is a B2B product-and-service business selling to restaurants, cafes, food courts, ghost-kitchen storefronts, and hotels. Revenue comes from per-replica fabrication (each dish modeled) plus optional display stands and menu-design integration. Recurring income comes from seasonal menu updates and new-item models. Buyers are restaurant owners who want higher average order value and fewer "this isn't what I expected" complaints.

Startup Costs

You can make replicas yourself with polymer clay and resin, or source them in bulk from China and customize:

- Polymer clay, resin, acrylic paints, sealers: \$200–\$500 starter kit
- Silicone molding supplies (for repeatable shapes): \$150–\$300
- Pre-made fake-food bases from Alibaba (search "fake food model" / "food sample replica"): \$1.50–\$6.00 per piece at bulk, ~\$0.50 import freight each
- UV resin lamp / small tools: \$80–\$200
- Display stands / acrylic holders (Alibaba "acrylic menu display stand"): \$1–\$4 each in bulk
- Camera/lighting for product photos: \$100–\$250
- Simple GoHighLevel funnel + booking page: ~\$97/mo
- Sample portfolio set (make 6–8 hero dishes): \$150

Total to launch: \$800–\$1,800. Hybrid sourcing — import generic bases, hand-finish to match each client's real plating.

The Numbers

Per-replica economics when hand-finishishing imported bases:

- Imported base + freight: ~\$3.50 + resin/paint/sealer: ~~\$2.00 + 30–45 min labor~~ = ****\$5.50 material cost per replica****
- Sell price per replica: **\$35–\$60** (custom, matched to their dish)
- Profit per replica: **~\$30–\$54**

A typical restaurant menu has 20–40 items. A full menu package of 25 replicas:

- Cost: ~\$140 materials + labor
- Sell price: **\$1,200–\$1,800 per restaurant**
- Profit: **~\$900–\$1,500 per job**

Realistic monthly projection: Close 4 restaurants/mo at ~\$1,400 each = \$5,600 revenue, ~\$3,800–\$4,500 net. Add seasonal-update retainers (\$200–\$400 per refresh) and you stack recurring income on top of new installs.

How To Start

1. Make 6–8 stunning replica samples of popular dishes (burger, sushi roll, latte, pasta) for your portfolio.
2. Photograph them next to a real menu so owners instantly get the concept.
3. Build a GoHighLevel booking funnel with before/after and a "menu that sells for you" pitch.
4. Walk into 10 local restaurants with your sample tray — in-person demo crushes cold email here.
5. Quote per-menu packages; offer a discounted 5-item pilot to lower the entry barrier.
6. Photograph each install for your own content and ask the owner for a video testimonial.
7. Systematize: build silicone molds for common dishes so repeat builds get faster and cheaper.

Where To Get Customers

- In-person walk-ins to local restaurants with a physical sample tray (highest close rate)
- Restaurant owner Facebook groups and local hospitality associations
- Cold outreach to franchises and food-court tenants via LeadRipper lists
- Partnerships with menu printers and restaurant POS/marketing vendors for referrals
- Instagram Reels of the replicas being made — the craft content sells itself

Pro Tips

- Carry a physical sample to every pitch. Owners decide the moment they hold a perfect mini version of their own signature dish.
- Lead with the money math: fewer wrong orders, higher add-on sales, more five-star reviews. Frame it as a sales tool, not decoration.
- Build reusable silicone molds for staple items (fries, rice, common proteins) so your second and third clients cost a fraction of the first — that's where margin compounds.